

REGISTRY NO. 073 WORD Guilt CLUSTER Moral-Conscience DATE 04 March 2026

1. LINGUISTIC DATA

Hebrew Vocabulary

Root	Transliteration	Gloss	Key Reference
אשם	asham	to be guilty, bear guilt, incur guilt	Lev 5:2–5; Gen 42:21
אָשָׁם	asham (noun)	guilt offering — cultic resolution of guilt-liability	Lev 5:6; Isa 53:10
אָשָׁמָה	ashmah	guiltiness, guilt-state — the condition of having incurred liability	Ezr 9:6–7; 2Ch 28:13
אָוֶן	avon	iniquity/guilt/punishment — three-dimensional term covering act, state, and consequence	Psa 51:2; Isa 53:6; Lam 5:7
חַטָּא / חַטֵּאת	chet/chata'ah	sin — missing the mark; the act from which guilt derives	Psa 51:2–4
נָסָא	nasa (+ avon)	to bear/lift guilt — carrying the weight of guilt-liability	Lev 16:22; Isa 53:11

Greek Vocabulary

Term	Transliteration	Gloss	Key Reference
ἐνοχος	enochos	guilty, liable, subject to judgment — legal guilt establishing obligation	Matt 5:21–22; Heb 2:15; Jas 2:10
κατὰ κρίμα	katakrima	condemnation — the verdict of guilt; sentence following conviction	Rom 5:16–18; 8:1
κατακρίνω	katakrino	to condemn — the judicial act establishing guilt-verdict	Rom 8:3; Joh 8:10–11
ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin — missing the mark; the act generating guilt-liability	Rom 6:1–23; 8:2–3
συνείδησις	suneidesis	conscience — co-witness; the internal faculty registering guilt	Rom 2:15; Heb 9:14; 1Ti 1:5
αἰτία / αἰτίος	aitia / aitios	cause/guilt/charge — legal ground for liability; 'no guilt' declaration	Joh 18:38; 19:4,6; Luk 23:4

Data source: STEP Bible STEP export. High Confidence classification. Core vocabulary: ashame root family (OT guilt-offering system), avon (three-dimensional), enochos (legal liability), katakrima (verdict-condemnation), suneidesis (conscience as internal witness). Note: suneidesis is the most significant NT addition — it provides the internal faculty through which guilt is experienced, not merely the external verdict. This creates a complete guilt system: act (hamartia/chet) → state (ashmah/enochos) → verdict (katakrima) → internal signal (suneidesis) → resolution (asham offering/Rom 8:1).

2. KEY EXEGETICAL FINDINGS

2.1 Romans 8:1 — Theological Resolution of Guilt

"There is therefore now no condemnation (katakrima) for those who are in Christ Jesus."

The most theologically decisive guilt text in the NT. Katakrima is the verdict-word — not merely a feeling of guilt but the formal judicial sentence. The resolution is positional: 'in Christ Jesus.' The mechanism is established in vv.2–4: the law of the Spirit of life liberates from the law of sin and death; God condemned sin in the flesh of his Son so that the righteous requirement of the law might be fulfilled in those who walk by the Spirit. Guilt is not dissolved by self-improvement — it is transferred judicially. This text is the NT apex of the entire guilt vocabulary.

Framework B implication: The guilt-faculty's resolution is never self-generated. The three-state typology's functioning state (1) is not 'guilt-free through effort' but 'guilt-resolved through atonement.' Rom 8:1 is the doctrinal statement of what the asham (guilt offering) system in Leviticus anticipated structurally.

2.2 Psalm 51:1–5 — Deepest OT Portrait of Guilt as Inner Experience

"Have mercy on me, O God... Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity (avon), and cleanse me from my sin (chet)... For I know my transgressions, and my sin is ever before me. Against you, you only, have I sinned."

David's prayer deploys three guilt-vocabulary terms simultaneously: avon (iniquity/guilt-state), chet (sin-act), pesha (transgression/rebellion). The triple vocabulary is not redundant — it maps the full anatomy of guilt: the rebellious act (pesha), the missing-the-mark dimension (chet), and the accumulated guilt-state (avon) that results. Critically, v.4 identifies God as the primary reference point: 'Against you, you only, have I sinned.' Guilt in the biblical framework is always fundamentally theocentric — not primarily about psychological distress or social liability but about broken covenant relationship with God.

The inner-experience dimension: 'my sin is ever before me' (v.3) — guilt as persistent cognitive presence, not resolving, haunting consciousness. Consistent with psychological research on unresolved guilt's intrusive cognition pattern.

2.3 Isaiah 53:10–11 — Asham as Christological Fulfilment

"When his soul makes an offering for guilt (asham)... by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous, for he shall bear their iniquities (avon)."

The guilt offering (asham) system in Leviticus required precise compensation plus twenty percent — it was not merely symbolic but restitutionary. Isa 53:10 applies the asham term directly to the Servant's death: his soul is the guilt offering. The mechanism: bearing iniquities (nasa avon — Lev 16:22 uses the identical phrase for the scapegoat carrying Israel's guilt into the wilderness). The trajectory: asham → seeing offspring → prolonged days → will of the Lord prospering. Guilt-bearing is not the end — it produces justified many.

Cross-card link: Isa 53:11 uses the same nasa avon ('bear iniquities') as the anguish card's redemptive-anguish analysis. The Servant's anguish (53:11a) and guilt-bearing (53:11b) are inseparable: guilt is borne within anguish; anguish is the cost of guilt-transfer.

2.4 Leviticus 5 — The Guilt Offering System: Structural Mechanics

"When he realizes his guilt (asham) in any of these... he shall confess his sin (chet)... and he shall bring to the Lord his compensation (asham) for the sin." (Lev 5:5–6)

The asham offering is the most legally precise of OT sacrificial categories. It activates when: (a) an obligation has been created by a specific act, (b) the person recognises the guilt (asham verb — 'comes to know it'), (c) restitution plus twenty percent is required. Three stages are structurally mandated: recognition → confession → restitution/offering. The guilt-faculty has a built-in recognition function. Lev 5:2–5 repeats 'he realizes his guilt' four times in consecutive verses — the recognition moment is foundational. Without recognition, the resolution mechanism cannot engage.

This is the biblical model for guilt's functional role: guilt is not a pathology to be suppressed but a signal triggering a specific resolution sequence. The functioning guilt-faculty works as intended when it moves the person through recognition → confession → restitution.

2.5 Romans 2:15 — Suneidesis: The Conscience as Universal Internal Witness

"They show that the work of the law is written on their hearts, while their conscience (suneidesis) also bears witness, and their conflicting thoughts accuse or even excuse them."

Suneidesis (sun- = with, eidesis = knowledge) — 'co-knowledge,' the faculty that knows what one has done and adds its testimony to it. Rom 2:15 establishes conscience as universal — not exclusive to Israel or the church but embedded in all image-bearers. Its function is testimonial: it 'bears witness' (marturous■) — judicial language. Conflicting thoughts 'accuse or even excuse' — the conscience operates as internal prosecutor and defence counsel simultaneously.

Hebrews adds the decisive dimension: blood of Christ 'purifies the conscience from dead works' (Heb 9:14); the old system could not 'perfect the conscience of the worshiper' (Heb 9:9); the goal is 'hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience' (Heb 10:22). The conscience-purification language in Hebrews maps directly onto the guilt-resolution trajectory of the entire OT system. Conscience is the internal register of guilt-state; its purification is the experiential side of what katakrima-removal (Rom 8:1) accomplishes judicially.

2.6 Matthew 5:21–22 — Enochos: The Graduated Guilt Scale

"You have heard... whoever murders shall be liable (enochos) to judgment. But I say... whoever is angry... shall be liable to judgment; whoever says... shall be liable to the council; whoever says... shall be liable (enochos) to the hell of fire."

Jesus uses enochos in a graduated series — three levels of guilt-liability corresponding to different acts. Enochos is the legal term: 'subject to,' 'liable to,' 'within the jurisdiction of.' The escalation from judgment → council → gehenna extends guilt-liability inward: not just the act of murder but the anger that precedes it. Jesus is not relaxing the law's guilt category but extending its reach into the interior of the soul.

Framework B implication: Guilt in Jesus's teaching is not confined to external acts — it reaches inner dispositions. This connects guilt directly to the moral-conscience cluster: if anger (4) generates enochos-liability, then the anger-faculty's distortion has guilt consequences. The moral-conscience system is a unified field: distorted anger → guilt → need for resolution.

2.7 Genesis 42:21 and Hosea 5:15 — Guilt-Recognition as Turning Point

"In truth we are guilty (ashem) concerning our brother, in that we saw the distress of his soul... That is why this distress has come upon us." (Gen 42:21)

"Until they acknowledge their guilt (ashem) and seek my face, and in their distress earnestly seek me." (Hos 5:15)

Two paradigmatic cases of guilt-recognition as structural turning point. Gen 42:21: Joseph's brothers, years later, connect present distress to past guilt — the guilt-faculty has retained the record. The recognition ('we are guilty') activates the relational awareness: 'the distress of his soul... that is why this distress has come upon us.' Guilt recognised produces empathy retrospectively — the brothers begin to see Joseph's suffering from his perspective. Guilt-recognition is the mechanism of moral restoration in this narrative.

Hos 5:15: God withdraws until guilt is acknowledged. The guilt-recognition → God-seeking sequence is covenantal — God's return to relationship is contingent on the guilt-faculty functioning correctly. Where guilt is suppressed, the covenantal relationship cannot be restored. This is the negative proof of the asham offering's structure: no recognition, no resolution.

3. SEMANTIC RANGE

3.1 The Guilt–Shame Distinction: The Lewis/Tangney Framework

The most analytically significant finding in the guilt vocabulary is the confirmation of a Hebrew/Greek parallel to the Lewis (1971) and Tangney et al. (1992) psychological distinction between guilt and shame:

Dimension	Shame	Guilt
Focus	Self ('I am bad')	Act ('I did something bad')
Hebrew vocabulary	bosh / kelimmah (identity signal)	asham / avon (act-liability)
Greek vocabulary	aischune / entropē (exposure signal)	enochos / katakrima (verdict-liability)
Faculty location	Affective + moral-conscience	Moral-conscience + judicial
Resolution	Honour-restoration (Isa 61:7)	Guilt-offering / katakrima-removal (Rom 8:1)
Pathological form	Toxic shame — chronic identity wound	False guilt — liability where none exists; or unresolved guilt

The distinction holds in the biblical vocabulary. Bosh/kelimmah (shame) operate primarily at identity level — they signal a state of the person. Asham/avon operate primarily at act-liability level — they signal an obligation incurred by a specific act. The difference is not absolute (they co-occur in Psa 51 — 'my sin is ever before me' is guilt-language; Ezr 9:6 'I am ashamed' is shame-language, but the same prayer contains both). However, the vocabulary distinction confirms that the biblical world distinguished these dimensions of the moral-conscience system.

3.2 Avon: The Three-Dimensional Guilt Term

The avon root is the most semantically complex term in the guilt cluster. It covers three distinct but related dimensions simultaneously: (1) the act of iniquity (crime/sin — what was done), (2) the guilt-state resulting from the act (the accumulated liability), and (3) the punishment/consequence flowing from the guilt. This three-dimensional semantic range is theologically significant: it maps the complete causal chain from act to consequence within a single lexeme.

Psalm 51:2 uses avon alongside chet (sin-act) and pesha (transgression) — three terms for the same moral failure at three different levels. Lamentations 5:7 ('Our fathers sinned, and are no more; and we bear their iniquities/avon') shows avon's generational dimension — the guilt-consequences of previous generations carried by subsequent ones. This is the guilt parallel to the shame-card's generational shame data (Dan 9:7–8).

3.3 Suneidesis: Conscience as Internal Guilt Register

Suneidesis is the NT's most important addition to the guilt vocabulary. It names the internal faculty that registers guilt-state independent of external verdict. Its range in the NT: good conscience (Acts 23:1; 1Ti 1:5) — guilt-faculty clear, no unresolved liability; weak conscience (1Cor 8:7,10) — guilt-faculty hypersensitive, extending liability where none exists; seared conscience (1Ti 4:2) — guilt-faculty disabled, no longer registering liability that does exist; evil/defiled conscience (Heb 10:22; Tit 1:15) — guilt-faculty inverted, registering clean things as guilty.

The suneidesis data confirms the three-state typology independently: functioning (good conscience), disabled (seared conscience), inverted (defiled conscience detecting wrong in what is right). This is the NT's own typology of the conscience/guilt-faculty, emerging from the vocabulary without being imported from the shame-card analysis.

4. THREE-STATE TYPOLOGY APPLIED

State	Biblical Evidence	Soul Condition	Conscience State
(1) Functioning	Lev 5:2–5 (guilt recognised → confession → resolution); Psa 51 (guilt acknowledged → God sought); Gen 42:21 (guilt recognised → relational restoration)	Guilt-faculty intact: recognises liability, triggers confession and restitution sequence, moves through resolution	Good conscience (Acts 23:1; 1Ti 1:5) — clear, no unresolved liability
(2) Disabled	1Ti 4:2 (seared conscience); Hos 13:16 (bears guilt but no recognition); Jer 2:35 ('I have not sinned' — denial of guilt-state)	Guilt-faculty silenced or suppressed: liability exists but internal recognition signal absent; guilt not experienced though present	Seared conscience (1Ti 4:2) — cauterised, no longer registering
(3) Inverted	Tit 1:15 (defiled conscience — 'nothing is pure'); Isa 5:20 (calling evil good); Heb 10:2 reversed — hypersensitive to what is clean	Guilt-faculty detecting liability where none exists (false guilt) or treating clean things as guilty; moral perception reversed	Defiled/evil conscience (Tit 1:15; Heb 10:22) — registers wrong thing as guilty

Typology note: The suneidesis vocabulary independently confirms all three states. The typology is not imposed from the shame-card — it emerges from the guilt vocabulary's own NT conscience data. This is the fourth consecutive confirmation (after shame, anger, and now guilt) of the three-state typology as a structural feature of evaluative soul-faculties in biblical anthropology.

5. SOUL FUNCTION IN FRAMEWORK B

5.1 Faculty Location

Faculty	Guilt's Role	Key Text
Moral-conscience (primary)	Guilt is the act-liability signal of the moral-conscience faculty — registering specific acts as generating obligation	Lev 5:2–5; Rom 2:15
Judicial / covenantal	Guilt as legal verdict — enochos, katakrima — establishing formal liability before God	Matt 5:21–22; Rom 5:16–18
Cognitive	Guilt as persistent cognitive presence — 'my sin is ever before me' — guilt-consciousness disrupting normal cognition	Psa 51:3; Rom 7:7–25
Volitional	Guilt-recognition triggers confession/restitution sequence — guilt activates the will toward resolution	Lev 5:5; Hos 5:15; 1Jo 1:9
Relational	Guilt disrupts vertical relationship with God (Hos 5:15 — God withdraws) and horizontal with others (Gen 42:21)	Psa 51:4; Gen 42:21

5.2 Guilt's Structural Position in the Moral-Conscience Cluster

Guilt occupies the act-judicial pole of the moral-conscience faculty, while shame occupies the identity-experiential pole. Together they constitute the complete subjective side of the moral-conscience system: shame signals 'I am in a state of moral failure' (identity); guilt signals 'I have incurred a specific obligation by this act' (liability). Neither is complete without the other in the biblical anthropology. Psalm 51 is the definitive demonstration: David's prayer deploys both — the shame-vocabulary (Ezr 9:6 equivalent: 'I am ashamed and blush') and the guilt-vocabulary (avon/chet/pesha — specific liability) simultaneously. The resolution addresses both: cleansing (shame-removal) and atonement (guilt-resolution).

The relationship to the rest of the moral-conscience cluster: Pride (123) generates the conditions of both shame and guilt — the incurvatus soul's acts generate guilt-liability; its state generates shame-awareness. Abomination (1) names what God perceives in the guilt/shame-producing soul. Humility (80) is the soul-condition in which guilt is properly acknowledged rather than suppressed or defended. Anger (4) cross-links: Matt 5:21–22 establishes that distorted anger generates enochos-liability. Grief (72) cross-links: 2Cor 7:10 godly grief produces metanoia (which

requires guilt-acknowledgment). The moral-conscience cluster is a unified system — guilt is its act-judicial node.

6. NEUROSCIENCE AND PSYCHOLOGY

6.1 The Lewis/Tangney Guilt–Shame Distinction: Empirical Support

Lewis (1971) first distinguished guilt ('I did something bad') from shame ('I am bad'). Tangney et al. (1992) provided empirical validation: guilt is associated with approach motivation (wanting to repair, confess, make amends); shame is associated with withdrawal and hiding. Critically, guilt is associated with empathy and prosocial behaviour; toxic shame is associated with aggression and social withdrawal.

Biblical confirmation: Lev 5 guilt-offering sequence maps directly onto Tangney's approach-motivation pattern — recognition → confession → restitution. Gen 42:21 guilt-recognition producing empathy maps onto the guilt-empathy linkage. The biblical vocabulary anticipated the psychological distinction by over three millennia.

6.2 Conscience Neurology: Neural Correlates of Guilt

Anterior cingulate cortex (ACC): activated in guilt-related moral judgments; error-monitoring function corresponds to suneidesis's 'accusing' role in Rom 2:15. Prefrontal cortex: guilt involves perspective-taking (imagining how one's act appears to another) — ventromedial PFC damage impairs guilt capacity. Insula: overlap with shame circuitry but distinct activation pattern — guilt activates reparative motivation circuits (Tangney et al.), shame activates withdrawal circuits. This neural distinction maps precisely onto the biblical guilt-approach vs. shame-withdrawal data.

6.3 Unresolved Guilt: Psychological Pathology

Chronic unresolved guilt produces: intrusive cognition (Psa 51:3 — 'my sin is ever before me' — matches psychological 'guilt intrusions'), rumination, sleep disruption, depression risk, anxiety elevation. Brewin et al. (1996): guilt-based intrusive memories are more treatment-resistant than fear-based. Rom 7:14–25 (Paul's 'wretched man' passage) is the biblical portrait of unresolved guilt's psychological grip: 'what I want to do I do not do, but what I hate I do' — guilt about an act does not automatically resolve the act's repetition.

6.4 Epigenetic Dimension

Confidence level: Moderate. Lam 5:7 ('Our fathers sinned, and are no more; and we bear their iniquities') establishes generational guilt-bearing. Avon's three-dimensional range (act → guilt-state → punishment) maps onto intergenerational transmission of consequence. Epigenetic pathway: chronic guilt-stress produces HPA-axis dysregulation (shared pathway with shame — NR3C1 methylation). Van der Kolk (2014): unresolved guilt and shame are primary drivers of trauma-epigenetic changes. Yehuda et al. (2016): Holocaust survivor offspring show guilt-related stress-reactivity changes independent of direct trauma exposure. The guilt-epigenetic link is less direct than shame (no specific 'guilt gene' identified) but operates through the same cortisol/stress-reactivity pathway.

7. OPEN QUESTIONS AND SYNTHESIS FLAGS

FLAG 1 — GUILT-SHAME DISTINCTION CONFIRMED AS BIBLICAL

The Lewis/Tangney distinction is not a modern psychological import — it maps onto the biblical vocabulary with precision. Framework B must treat guilt (act-liability) and shame (identity-signal) as distinct but complementary dimensions of the moral-conscience faculty. Psa 51 is the definitive text showing both operating simultaneously in the same soul in the same prayer.

FLAG 2 — SUNEIDESIS AS THE INTERNAL GUILT-FACULTY

Conscience (suneidesis) is the NT's explicit name for the internal faculty that registers guilt-state. Its three-state typology (good → seared → defiled) independently confirms the functioning/disabled/inverted framework. Framework B should formally designate suneidesis as the NT term for the guilt-registering faculty, parallel to the shame-faculty (bosh/aischune cluster).

FLAG 3 — THE RESOLUTION SEQUENCE AS A FRAMEWORK B TOOL

Lev 5's three-stage sequence (recognition → confession → restitution/offering) is the most practically applicable tool in this card. It maps onto the psychological guilt-repair research (Tangney's approach motivation) and the NT's own pattern (1Jo 1:9: confess → forgiveness → cleansing). Framework B should formalise this as the guilt-resolution model. Critically, Rom 8:1 establishes that full resolution (katakrima-removal) requires atonement,

not merely self-repair.

FLAG 4 — FALSE GUILT (STATE 3 INVERSION) REQUIRES FURTHER ANALYSIS

The inverted conscience state (Tit 1:15 — defiled, detecting wrong in what is clean) describes what psychological literature calls 'false guilt' — guilt about acts that are not sinful. This is a pastorally significant category: many people carry guilt-loads that the biblical framework would identify as state-3 inversion rather than state-1 functioning. The theological question: is the seared conscience (state 2) more or less dangerous than the hypersensitive/defiled conscience (state 3)? The data suggests both are pathological but in opposite directions.

FLAG 5 — GENERATIONAL GUILT (LAM 5:7) AND AVON'S THREE DIMENSIONS

Avon's three-dimensional range (act → guilt-state → punishment) is not merely lexical — it maps a complete causal chain. Lam 5:7 generational avon-bearing is the guilt parallel to Dan 9:7–8 generational shame. Together they establish that both shame and guilt have intergenerational dimensions in the biblical framework. Epigenetic research on both pathways is the same (NR3C1/cortisol/HPA-axis). The guilt-card adds the avon-punishment dimension: not merely that guilt-stress is transmitted, but that the consequences of guilt-acts propagate across generations (Exo 20:5; 34:7 — 'visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children').

FLAG 6 — CROSS-CARD: GUILT AND FORGIVENESS PROJECT

The guilt-offering (asham) system is the structural mechanism that the forgiveness project must engage. You cannot have forgiveness without guilt-resolution; you cannot have guilt-resolution without acknowledgment of the specific liability incurred. The three-stage Lev 5 model (recognition → confession → restitution/offering) is the OT template for the forgiveness project's mechanism of relational restoration. Hos 5:15 confirms: genuine relationship restoration requires guilt-acknowledgment, not merely emotional reconciliation.

8. CROSS-CARD LINKS

Card	Link	Key Text
Shame (146)	Guilt = act-liability; shame = identity-signal. Complementary dimensions of moral-conscience. Psa 51 deploys both simultaneously.	Psa 51:2–4; Ezr 9:6–7
Pride (123)	Pride (incurvatus) generates conditions of both shame and guilt. The proud soul suppresses guilt-recognition (state 2 → seared conscience).	Jer 2:35 ('I have not sinned'); Hos 5:15
Humility (80)	Humility is the soul-posture in which guilt-recognition can occur. Moses anav = humble but fully acknowledged his failures. Humility makes state-1 functioning possible.	Lev 26:40–41; Hos 5:15
Anger (4)	Matt 5:21–22: anger generates enochos-liability. Distorted anger creates guilt. The anger-guilt connection confirms both faculties are nodes in the same moral-conscience system.	Matt 5:21–22
Grief (72)	Godly grief (2Cor 7:10) produces metanoia which requires guilt-acknowledgment. You cannot have genuine repentance without functioning guilt-faculty. Grief is the affective carrier of guilt toward resolution.	2Cor 7:10; Psa 51:17
Anguish (182)	Isa 53:10–11: Servant's anguish and guilt-bearing are inseparable. Nasa avon (bear iniquity) in 53:11 links guilt-transfer to redemptive anguish.	Isa 53:10–11
Abomination (1)	Abomination is what guilt-generating acts produce in God's moral perception. Toevah names the relational-moral category of what the guilty act is to God.	Pro 16:5; Eze 16:49
Forgiveness (project)	Asham system is the structural mechanism of guilt-resolution and the OT template for forgiveness. No forgiveness is complete without addressing guilt-liability (katakrima) as well as relational breach.	Lev 5:5–6; 1Jo 1:9; Rom 8:1